

Hope remains unchanged

Whether it is called the All India Football Federation, the Football Federation of Bharat, or the Supreme Council for Optimistic Ball Chasing, supporters will settle for something remarkably simple. **A team that wins** a few more matches.

Suresh Menon

Inspired by the All India Football Federation, I am toying with the idea of changing my name to V. S. Naipaul in order to win the Nobel Prize, or maybe to Usain Bolt to run the 100m in world record time. The AIFF is changing its name to Football Federation of Bharat, a move guaranteed to confuse the opposition which turns up for a match to play India. It's a good ploy.

When the team cannot consistently qualify for major tournaments, the least it can do is qualify for a new name. Every four years the World Cup reminds us how far behind the leading nations Indian football is. Platitudes, cliches, past glories (many imagined), the nearly cases, what happened in 1948, are all trotted out religiously. But this is the AIFF's first concrete step although it might suggest the concrete is elsewhere.

The beauty of renaming a football federation is that it requires no extra training sessions, no youth academies, no scouting network, and no troublesome questions about grassroots development. A new signboard is far cheaper than a new football culture.

Bharat, of course, is an ancient name with deep cultural resonance. Problem is, world rankings are notoriously insensitive to symbolism. Opponents continue to score goals regardless of what you call yourself. An Indian defence by any other name is just as porous, as Shakespeare nearly said before changing his name to Winston Churchill.

If names alone could transform footballing fortunes, every club would simply rename itself Real Madrid and wait for the trophies to arrive.

Indian football has lived through many eras. There have been promises of revolutions, roadmaps, visions, missions, and strategic blueprints. Now comes a new chapter: lexical development.

Perhaps young players in distant towns, seeing Football Federation of Bharat on a document, will



suddenly discover a new first touch or a more powerful header. Defenders will master positioning. Strikers will find the top corner. Midfielders will stop passing sideways.

Or perhaps football will continue to demand the old-fashioned things: pitches, coaches, competition, patience, and competence. That is the inconvenient aspect of sport. It insists on performance.

Performance has seen India trail 137 other countries in the current world rankings. The AIFF (or FFB) is yet to tell us that 138 is a magic number. But it is. 138 is what mathematicians call a sphenic number (a product of exactly three distinct prime numbers: $2 \times 3 \times 23$) and an abundant number (its proper divisors add up to more than the number itself).

Meanwhile, the federation's marketing department may finally have something to celebrate. New logos can be designed. New stationery can be printed. New social media handles can be debated. Somewhere, a printer manufacturer is preparing for a profitable season.

For the ordinary football fan, however, the hope remains unchanged. Whether it is called the All India Football Federation, the Football Federation of Bharat, or the Supreme Council for Optimistic Ball Chasing, supporters will settle for something remarkably simple. A team that wins a few more matches.